The Greek: Yoke or Temple of Unbelief

For a 5–10 year old

God says: do not tie yourself to someone who is walking the other way.

Light and dark do not share a room. Jesus and Satan do not sing the same song. God's house and pretend gods do not shake hands.

You are God's house if you belong to Him. He lives there. He walks there. He is your Father, and you are His child.

So step out of the middle of the other house. Do not pick up what does not belong in God's house. He will welcome you.

How unbelieving people connect to idols

A person who does not follow Jesus still has a house. Something else is living there.

They give that something their time. They live with it. They say yes to its voice. They stand with the people who follow it. They and that something decide together what the life will be.

It might be a pretend god. It might be their own idea, sitting where God should sit.

What temple we keep if we do not believe or follow Jesus

If Jesus does not live in the house, the house is not empty. Somebody else already got a yes.

Sometimes that somebody is the person's own wants: ***my plan, my hurt, my appetite, my name, my fear.*** Jesus and Satan do not share a house. If Jesus is not home, someone else is.

One temple for the Holy Spirit, one temple for a person's own ideas

One house has God's Spirit living in it. The other house has that person's own ideas in charge.

If you tie those two houses together, they want to walk two ways. Light and dark do not share a room. Jesus and Satan do not sing the same song. If they pretend to say one yes, one voice gets quieter.

They did not become one house. They only pretended.

"Friend," "Christian," or something else

This is not a list of who you may not love. God wants you to be kind.

It is about who you tie your life to.

Someone you call a "friend" can still be walking the other way. You can be kind to them and still not tie God's house to their house.

Someone you call a “Christian” might only be wearing the name. Look at who lives in the house.

They might not be the “friend” you thought. They might not be a “Christian” either. They might be asking you to walk with another god and call it fine. God’s child steps out of that. God looks at the house, not the name.

For a teenager

Do not hitch your life to someone who does not trust God, as if the two of you were pulling the same load. That hitch is a different yoke. Paul asks five questions that all mean the same thing. What share do right and wrong have? What common life do light and dark have? What harmony do Christ and Belial sing together? What lot do a person who trusts God and a person who does not trust God split between them? What joint consent does God’s house make with idols?

Then he says the plain thing. You are God’s house. The living God said He would live in you and walk around in your life. So come out from the middle of a life that has already chosen other gods. Do not handle what is unclean. God will take you in. He will be your Father. You will be His sons and daughters.

This is about whose house your life is. If you call someone a “friend,” or if they call themselves a “Christian,” ask what is actually living in the house. A label on the door does not decide the tenant.

How unbelieving people connect to idols

Someone who does not trust God still has a house. Something is living in it. The passage names five ways that house stays tied to an idol.

They give the idol a cut of their life. Time, money, a secret, a habit they defend as “just who I am.”

They live with it. It is not a one-time visit. The room stays dark because they never asked the light to stay.

They agree with its voice. Accusation, lust, pride, fear, or a lie gets called “my truth” or “my peace.”

They take their place with people who do not trust God. A family story, a friend group, or an inner promise assigns them a share that is not God’s people.

They vote with the idol. “This is what we have decided our life is.” A statue is one kind of idol. A person’s own ideas, obeyed in God’s place, are another.

What temple we keep if we do not believe or follow Jesus

If Jesus is not the one living and walking in your life, the house is not empty. It has already agreed with something else.

Often that something else is you: ***my plan, my hurt, my appetite, my name, my fear.*** Those get the vote, as if they were god. The passage names Belial because that agreement is not a

blank. Christ does not sing with him. A house that will not have Christ has already answered someone.

One temple for the Holy Spirit, one temple for a person's own ideas

One life has the Holy Spirit living and walking in it. The other life has that person's own ideas sitting in charge. If those two lives hitch together, they are built to pull two ways and are being asked to pull one.

They try to share one decision, as if right and wrong could own it together. They try to live one life, as if light and dark could keep the same house. They try to sing one song, and Christ and Belial will not. Someone's voice gets quieter. They try to split one future between a person who trusts God and a person who does not.

The strongest hitch is a joint yes. That can be a marriage. It can also be any "we" that decides what the life will worship: a bond, a partnership, a promise of loyalty. If one yes belongs to the Spirit and the other yes belongs to familiar spirit suggestions, the two houses have not become one house. They have been forced to pretend.

"Friend," "Christian," or something else

This passage is not a rule about who you are allowed to marry. Paul already said a husband or wife should stay with a spouse who does not trust Jesus, if that spouse is willing to stay. It is also not only a rule about who you can sit with. Jesus ate with people other religious people avoided.

The question is the hitch. One share. One life. One voice. One future. One yes.

Calling someone a "friend" does not settle it. You can love a neighbor and still refuse to hitch your worship to them. Kindness is not the yoke. A shared yes is.

Calling someone a "Christian" does not settle it either. They can wear the name while the house has agreed with an idol, or with their own ideas in God's place. If your life and theirs cannot share what is right, the light, Christ, a holy future, and a clean yes, the name does not make the hitch equal.

They may be neither the "friend" you meant nor the "Christian" you hoped. They may be someone whose life has already said yes to another god, asking you to pull with them and call it peace. God's house comes out of that agreement. The test is who lives in the house, not the title.

For a mature adult

> μὴ γίνεσθε ἑτεροζυγοῦντες ἀπίστοις· τίς γὰρ μετοχὴ δικαιοσύνῃ καὶ ἀνομίᾳ; ἢ τίς κοινωνία φωτὶ πρὸς σκότος;
>
> Do not become yoked with a different yoke to unbelievers. For what shared portion does righteousness have with lawlessness? Or what common life does light have with darkness?

> τίς δὲ συμφώνησις Χριστοῦ πρὸς Βελιάρ, ἢ τίς μερὶς πιστῷ μετὰ ἀπίστου;
>
> And what harmony does Christ have with Belial, or what lot does a faithful one have with an unbeliever?

> τίς δὲ συγκατάθεσις ναῷ θεοῦ μετὰ εἰδώλων; ἡμεῖς γὰρ ναὸς θεοῦ ἐσμεν ζῶντος, καθὼς εἶπεν ὁ θεὸς ὅτι ἐνοικήσω ἐν αὐτοῖς καὶ ἐμπεριπατήσω καὶ ἔσομαι αὐτῶν θεὸς καὶ αὐτοὶ ἔσονταί μου λαός.
>
> And what joint consent does the temple of God have with idols? For we are the temple of the living God, as God said: I will dwell in them and walk among them, and I will be their God, and they will be my people.

> διὸ ἐξέλθατε ἐκ μέσου αὐτῶν καὶ ἀφορίσθητε, λέγει κύριος, καὶ ἀκαθάρτου μὴ ἅπτεσθε· κἀγὼ εἰσδέξομαι ὑμᾶς
>
> Therefore come out from the middle of them and be set apart, says the Lord, and do not touch what is unclean, and I will receive you,

> καὶ ἔσομαι ὑμῖν εἰς πατέρα καὶ ὑμεῖς ἔσεσθέ μοι εἰς υἱοὺς καὶ θυγατέρας, λέγει κύριος παντοκράτωρ.
>
> and I will be a Father to you, and you will be sons and daughters to me, says the Lord Almighty.

2 Corinthians 6:14–18

Do not become people who are yoked with a different kind of yoke to the faithless. A different yoke is the picture of an ox and a donkey hitched to the same beam (Deuteronomy 22:10). Paul does not say “do not sit near them.” He says do not become the mismatched pair. The command is about a shared pull.

Then he stacks five questions, and each word is a tighter kind of sharing.

A shared portion. What share does righteousness have with lawlessness?

A common life. What common life does light have with darkness?

A harmony of voices. What accord does Christ have with Belial?

An assigned lot, a share of an inheritance. What lot does the faithful one have with the faithless one?

A joint consent, a vote put down together. What joint consent does the temple of God have with idols?

The last question names the real subject. We are the temple of the living God. God said He would dwell in them, walk among them, be their God, and they would be His people. The yoke Paul

forbids is two temples voting the same life: one house where the living God walks, and one house where idols are set down and agreed to.

Therefore come out from the middle of them and be marked off, says the Lord. Do not touch what is unclean, and I will receive you. I will be a Father to you, and you will be sons and daughters to Me, says the Lord Almighty.

The passage is a temple argument. Marriage is one kind of yoke in Scripture, and Paul already wrote the marriage rule in 1 Corinthians 7: an unbelieving husband or wife who is willing to stay is not to be sent away, and the believing spouse sanctifies that household. He would not cancel that rule a letter later by turning 6:14 into "who not to marry." The modern reader who hears only a dating slogan has stopped at the first verb and skipped the temple.

What the passage forbids is becoming one pull, one share, one voice, one lot, and one vote with a life whose temple is not the living God.

How unbelieving people connect to idols

The faithless in this passage are not defined by a missing church membership card. They are defined by the temple they keep. An idol is whatever sits in the place where God said He would dwell and walk. Unbelieving people connect to idols in ordinary ways, and the five words of the passage name the connections.

They share a portion with lawlessness. The idol gets a cut of the life: time, money, secrecy, a habit that is defended as "just who I am."

They keep a common life with darkness. The idol is not visited once. It is lived with. The room stays dark because the light was never invited to stay.

They sound together with Belial. The voice in the house agrees with accusation, lust, pride, fear, or a lie, and calls that agreement "my truth" or "my peace."

They take their lot with the faithless. Family story, friend group, nation, or inner vow assigns them a share that is not the people of God.

They cast the same vote as the idol. This is the deepest link. The person and the idol consent together. "This is what we have decided our life is."

A carved statue is one form. A person's own ideas, set in the holy place and obeyed, are another. The connection is consent, not carpentry.

What temple we keep if we do not believe or follow Jesus

If the living God is not the one who dwells and walks there, the life is still a temple. Paul does not describe an empty building. He describes a building that has come into agreement with idols. The alternative to "temple of the living God" in this paragraph is "temple in joint consent with idols."

A life that does not believe Jesus and does not follow Him keeps a temple for something else. Often the something else is the self: ***my plan, my hurt, my appetite, my name, my fear,*** treated as the god who gets the vote. Belial is named because the agreement is not neutral. Christ

has no harmony with him. A house that will not have Christ does not become a vacant house. It becomes a house that has already answered someone.

One temple for the Holy Spirit, one temple for a person's own ideas

When one life is a temple where the Holy Spirit dwells and walks, and the other life is a temple where that person's own ideas sit and rule, the five words describe the danger of tying them into one pull.

A different yoke makes them drag one direction while they are built for two. One is answering the Spirit. One is answering the familiar spirit's suggestion.

A shared portion splits righteousness with lawlessness, as if both could own the same decision.

A common life asks light to keep house with darkness.

A harmony asks Christ and Belial to sing one song. They will not. Someone's voice gets quieter.

A lot tries to give the faithful one and the faithless one one inheritance.

A joint vote is the marriage-shaped part of the picture, and it is also wider than a wedding. It is any strong agreement in which two people put their yes down together: a bond, a partnership, a vow of loyalty, a "we" that decides what the life will worship. If one yes belongs to the Spirit and the other yes belongs to familiar spirit suggestions, the agreement is a mismatched yoke. The temples have not become one temple. They have been forced to pretend they are.

"Friend," "Christian," or something else

At no point should the modern reader take this passage as a rule about who not to marry. Paul already told husbands and wives what to do with an unbelieving spouse who is willing to remain (1 Corinthians 7:12–16). Second Corinthians 6 does not repeal that. It is not a verse for breaking a marriage, and it is not a verse whose first job is choosing a spouse.

It is also not a verse whose job is only "who to be good friends with," if "friend" means the person you eat with, work beside, or show kindness to. Jesus ate with people the religious sort avoided. The command is narrower and heavier than a social list. It is about becoming yoked: one portion, one common life, one voice, one lot, one joint consent.

So the question is not settled by what we call them.

A person we call a "friend" may be a neighbor we love and do not yoke our worship to. Kindness is not the yoke. Joint consent is.

A person we call a "Christian" may be wearing the name while the house has agreed with an idol, or with their own ideas in God's place. The name on the mouth is not the tenant in the temple. If their life and ours cannot share righteousness, light, Christ, a holy lot, and a clean vote, calling them a "Christian" does not make the yoke equal.

They may be neither the "friend" we meant nor the "Christian" we hoped. They may be a faithless yoke: a life in agreement with another god, asking us to pull with them and call it peace. The passage tells the temple of the living God to come out from the middle of that agreement, be

marked off, refuse what is unclean, and be received as sons and daughters. The test is the temple, not the title.
